

everydaySPY

4 Spy Tools to Combat Anxiety

Take Back Control in an Uncertain World

by Emma Becker



The world population is experiencing anxiety at unprecedented levels.

40 Million US adults report suffering from anxiety every year.

In the United States, 40 million adults report suffering from anxiety every year. Anxiety impacts nearly two women for every one man, commonly starting at adolescence. Your best income-building and family-building years are also the years you are most likely to develop an anxiety disorder, between the ages of 30-44.

Anxiety is defined as intense, excessive, persistent worry and fear about everyday situations and uncertain outcomes. Just like you, Intelligence professionals also encounter feelings of anxiety and worry. But what sets us apart from the general population is that we are trained to overcome and control our anxiety.

Your prime earning and family years are also the years you are most likely to develop anxiety disorder.

As a SIGINT (signals intelligence) specialist, I had to listen to terrible things: sounds of violence and beheadings, sick plans evil people make in private, horrible activities in hidden basements and faraway caves. Being exposed to another person's trauma weighs heavy on the soul.

As a SIGINT specialist, I had to hear terrible things... get exposed to other people's trauma.

I was immersed in a world most don't know exists. It forced me to try to become one person in my professional life and a different person in my personal life. Except I couldn't unhear what SIGINT played for me. So my professional life bled into my personal life and I started seeing the worst-case scenario in everything I did... all the time.

When I moved into my first apartment, I insisted that I not be on the bottom floor or in an apartment with windows facing the front door. Though I was confident in my hand-to-hand combat skills, I wanted to ensure I had every advantage against a predator, rapist, or thief.



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I installed a glass-shatter detection alarm in my first house. I built a panic room, then realized my panic room would not withstand a fire so I closed it off. I trained a fierce 130-lb German Shepherd that I got from Germany, bred for home protection, personal security and drug detection. Even though my dog was trained to withstand beatings and mace, my anxiety still ate away at me and reminded me that the dog could be shot and killed by an intruder.

I slept with a KA-BAR under my mattress, rock-climbing shoes next to my bed, and had an evac route out my window.

I was suffering from a cognitive distortion intel professionals call, 'Catastrophizing.'

I was sleeping with a KA-BAR under my mattress, rock-climbing shoes next to my bed, and I had an evac route planned out of my second story bedroom window to the roof of my house. I thought my plan was rock solid, even if an intruder made it into my home, past the alarms, shot my dog, and made it up to my bedroom...

Then I shared my plan with a good friend and Iraq/Afghanistan combat veteran. He listened patiently, looked at me in disbelief, and said, "Emma, that's not normal. Your plan is a bit extreme."

And it struck me. My worst-case thinking had become so normal, so second nature to me that I fell victim to anxiety without even realizing it! I was suffering from a cognitive distortion Intel professionals call, 'Catastrophizing.'

Cognitive distortions are thought patterns that cause recurring negative views of reality. Catastrophizing is a distortion that causes you to always assume the worst outcome - a catastrophe. It creates a false sense that you are in a dire circumstance when in reality you are not.

Cognitive distortions are thought patterns that cause recurring negative views of reality.

For me personally, I expected somebody to break into my home, kill my dog, and come up to my bedroom



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Catastrophizing creates a toxic sense of worry that is artificial!

and attack me. Simple, everyday events (like going to sleep in the comfort of my own home) caused anxiety, which only multiplied over the course of the day. Catastrophizing creates a pressing, toxic sense of worry that is totally artificial - even though it can feel real.

Once I saw my own distortion in action, I knew I had to take action. And my Intel training had already prepared me with the tools to win. I just need to execute my mission and take back control.

Use these 4 Spy Tools to Combat Anxiety and Take Back Control:

1. Eating to Combat Anxiety
2. Quiet to Combat Anxiety
3. Exercise to Combat Anxiety
4. Sleep to Combat Anxiety

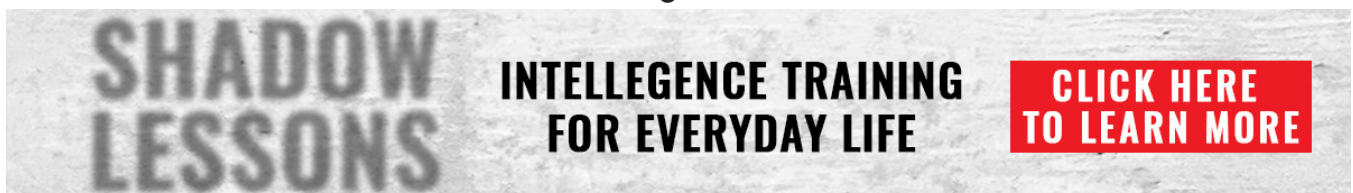
Tool #1: Eating to Combat Anxiety

Operators in the field work hard to eat a wide variety of whole foods, including fruits, vegetables, grains, nuts, seeds, legumes, and high-quality protein sources. Natural, unrefined foods are critical for overall physical and mental health and wellness. Eating a diverse whole foods diet feeds your brain and body the core vitamins, minerals and nutrients they need to thrive under stress and outside performance demands.

Operators in the field work hard to eat a wide variety of whole foods.

Nutrition rich diets improve sleep and decision making, dropping anxiety nearly overnight.

When I tweaked my eating to consume more fruits, vegetables, and high-quality proteins, I started to see through the fog of baseless fear that had become so common to me. I started sleeping better, my decision making improved, and my anxiety started to decrease almost overnight.



Tool #2: Quiet to Combat Anxiety

To beat the negative thoughts and voices in my head (both my catastrophizing distortion and the haunting SIGINT traumas I had heard), I needed to face my thoughts directly. This type of internal processing has many names: meditation, prayer, self-reflection, etc. To me, the terminology matters less than the action itself.

In my own practice I put on noise cancelling headphones and sat in an empty room, eyes closed. In this quiet space, I could acknowledge the catastrophizing thoughts that swirled around in my mind. I listened to everything the negative thoughts had to say. I relived screams, pain, confusion, and frustration I had heard and felt.

an ongoing meditation routine that still gives me the peace of mind I need to withstand even the most brutal days at work and at home.

Tool #3: Exercise to Combat Anxiety

Low intensity exercise for as little as 30 minutes a day benefits multiple aspects of your mind and body. Exercise improves blood flow to the brain, reduces body inflammation, and lowers stress hormone levels – all of which are important to healthy mental functions. Pairing physical activity with a mental stimulus like meditation can also elevate cognitive skills and analytical thinking.

I made exercise a critical component in combating my anxiety. I mixed intense

To beat the negative voices in your own head, you need to face them directly.

Face each fear head-on and quiet them by rationally thinking through each one.

I faced each terror head-on and then quieted them by rationally thinking through each event. And I developed

Exercise moves blood to the brain, reduces body inflammation, and lowers stress hormones.



(HIIT) workouts with restorative yoga to release endorphins that reset stress hormones that had long been out of balance.

Tool #4: Sleep to Combat Anxiety

Most adults need between seven and nine hours of sleep a night to maximize anti-anxiety benefits. Healthy

Quality sleep makes your other 3 Spy Tools even more effective to combat anxiety.

sleep habits boost the immune system, reduce stress levels, and even balance blood-sugar levels.

I know a consistent sleep routine can be difficult for working parents and busy professionals. I succeed by setting “non-negotiables” that help me keep sleep a priority. For example, I do not watch tv and stay away from my phone from dinner onward. I also tap into Spy Tool #2

and create a quiet restful environment using meditative music, aromatic oils, and an old fashioned paper book about an hour before I intend to sleep.

Even when my kiddos disrupt my pre-bedtime routine, I am in a calmer and more patient headspace to deal with the interruptions - a big secondary win for me!

Your brain doesn't play fair when it comes to anxiety... So neither should you.

Finally, good quality sleep boosts the effectiveness of the other 3 Spy Tools that combat anxiety! As you improve in any one anxiety-destroying practice, you get closer to winning the war on cognitive distortions.

Your brain doesn't play fair when it comes to anxiety. So neither should you.

Godspeed, #EverydaySpy



ABOUT THE AUTHOR *Emma Becker, former US Navy intel officer and United States Naval Academy graduate. Emma is a decorated veteran and graduate of the Institute for Integrative Nutrition. She is a proud partner of EverydaySpy.com and the founder of [HauteWellness.com](https://www.hautewellness.com), a holistic wellness practice based in Washington state.*

